MAHATMA GANDHI UNIVERSITY, KOTTAYAM

MGU-UGP (HONOURS) REGULAR EXAMINATION MARCH 2025

SECOND SEMESTER

Multi-Disciplinary Courses (MDC) - MG2MDCPES101 - INTRODUCTION TO YOGA

Answer Key

Part A – Multiple Choice Questions **[1 x 10 = 10 marks]**

1. b) The alignment and positioning of the body
2. a) Focusing on breath and meditative awareness
3. d) Prayer Pose
4. a) Asana
5. c) Mantra Meditation
6. a) Pranayama
7. c) Enhances concentration and mental clarity
8. d) Strengthen lower back & core
9. b) Revolved Triangle Pose
10. a) Neti pot

Part B – Short Answer Questions **[5 × 2 = 10 marks]**

11. What causes Bow Legs, and how is it treated in yoga? Bow legs is a condition where the knees remain wide apart when standing with feet together, forming a bow-like shape in the legs.

Causes:

1. Vitamin D deficiency (Rickets).
2. Improper walking habits in childhood.
3. Bone deformity by birth.
4. Improper sitting posture (W-sitting).

Virabhadrasana (Warrior Pose), Vrikshasana (Tree Pose) , Garudasana (Eagle Pose) , Baddha Konasana (Butterfly Pose) and Upavistha Konasana (Seated Angle Pose)

12. What is the purpose of using Ujjayi breathing during asanas? Ujjayi breathing helps maintain rhythm, focus the mind, and enhance oxygen flow. It supports deeper awareness and stability during postures and helps regulate body temperature.

13. Write about Mindful Yoga? Mindful yoga combines traditional yoga postures (asanas) with mindfulness meditation techniques. It encourages practitioners to focus on their body, breath, and thoughts in the present moment, without judgment. The goal of mindful yoga is to cultivate a deeper connection to one's physical and mental experiences, promoting inner peace and awareness.

14. Which ancient civilization provides evidence of early Yoga practices? The Indus Valley Civilization provides archaeological evidence such as seals depicting yoga-like postures, indicating the early practice of yoga around 3000 BCE.

15. What does "Padahastasana" mean in Sanskrit? *Padahastasana* means Hand-to-Foot Pose (*Pada* = foot, *Hasta* = hand, *Asana* = posture). It is a standing forward bend that stretches the back and legs.

16. What are any four physical benefits of practicing yoga? (any four points)

1. Improved Flexibility – Yoga stretches the muscles and increases the range of motion in joints.
2. Enhanced Muscle Strength – Holding poses builds strength in both major and stabilizing muscle groups.
3. Better Posture – Awareness and alignment in yoga improve spinal posture and reduce strain.
4. Increased Balance and Coordination – Many pose challenges and develop balance and body awareness.
5. Improved Breathing and Lung Capacity – Pranayama and breath control enhance respiratory efficiency.
6. Boosted Circulation – Yoga improves blood flow, helping oxygen reach tissues more effectively.
7. Joint Health – Gentle movement in yoga lubricates joints and prevents degeneration.
8. Better Digestion – Twisting and compressing poses stimulate internal organs and digestive function.
9. Weight Management – Combined with mindfulness, yoga can aid in healthy weight control.

10. Pain Relief – It can reduce chronic pain, especially in the back, neck, and joints.

17. What are the benefits of Ustrasana? *Ustrasana* (Camel Pose) Benefits:

1. Improves Posture – Opens the chest and strengthens the back muscles.
2. Enhances Spinal Flexibility – Stretches the entire spine and relieves stiffness.
3. Boosts Lung Capacity – Expands the chest and improves breathing.
4. Strengthens the Core & Thighs – Engages the abdominal and leg muscles.
5. Stimulates Digestion – Activates abdominal organs and improves metabolism.
6. Relieves Stress & Anxiety – Helps release tension and enhances mental clarity.

Part C – Short Essay Questions **[3 × 5 = 15 marks]**

18. Explain the techniques of Salabhasana and Dhanurasana.

Salabhasana (Locust Pose) : "Salabha" means locust, symbolizing alertness and vitality. Salabhasana, or Locust Pose, is a prone-lying backbend in yoga that involves lifting the chest, arms, and legs off the ground simultaneously. This pose strengthens the posterior chain, improves spinal flexibility, and enhances overall body posture.

Technique:

1. Starting Position: Lie flat on your stomach, with legs extended and arms alongside the body.
2. Hand & Leg Placement: Keep palms facing upward and legs together.
3. Lifting Movement: Inhale and simultaneously lift the chest, arms, and legs off the ground.
4. Hold the Position: Keep the core engaged and maintain the pose for a few breaths.
5. Return to Start: Exhale and slowly bring the body back to the floor.

Dhanurasana (Bow Pose) : "Dhanur" means bow, as the pose mimics the shape of a bow with the body as the bowstring. Dhanurasana, or Bow Pose, is a prone-lying backbend in yoga where the body takes the shape of a bow, with the torso and legs forming the curved part and the arms acting as the bowstring. It strengthens the back, improves flexibility, and stimulates internal organs.

Technique:

1. Starting Position: Lie flat on your stomach, legs extended, and arms by your sides.
2. Bend the Knees: Bring your heels close to the buttocks.
3. Grip the Ankles: Reach back and hold the ankles with your hands.
4. Lift & Stretch: Inhale and lift the chest and thighs off the ground while pulling the ankles upward.
5. Hold the Position: Maintain balance and keep breathing steadily.
6. Return to Start: Exhale and slowly release the pose, bringing the chest and legs back to the floor.

19. Write any two breathing techniques with its steps. (any two)

1. Dirgha Pranayama (Three-Part Breath):

   Technique: Inhale deeply into the abdomen, ribcage, and chest in three distinct stages. Exhale slowly and completely.

   Benefits: Encourages full oxygenation of the lungs and promotes relaxation, reducing stress and improving focus.

2. Nadi Shodhana (Alternate Nostril Breathing):

   Technique: Inhale through one nostril, then exhale through the other nostril. Alternate sides after each breath.

   Benefits: Balances the energy channels (nadis) in the body, calms the mind, and reduces stress and anxiety.

3. Kapalabhati (Skull-Shining Breath):

   Technique: Perform forceful exhalations through the nose, followed by passive inhalations.

   Benefits: Energizes the body, clears the respiratory system, and sharpens mental focus.

4. Bhramari (Bee Breath):

   Technique: Inhale deeply and then exhale with a humming sound, resembling the sound of a bee.

   Benefits: Relieves anxiety, calms the nervous system, and enhances concentration and mental clarity.

5. Ujjayi (Victorious Breath):

   Technique: Breathe deeply through the nose with a slight constriction at the back of the throat, creating a soft "ocean" sound.

   Benefits: Enhances focus, improves endurance, and helps synchronize breath with movement during asana practice.

20. Explain the eight limbs of Raja Yoga as per Patanjali’s Yoga Sutras.

The Eight Limbs of Raja Yoga (Patanjali's Yoga Sutras):

- Yama (Restraints): Ethical guidelines for interactions with others and oneself.
- Niyama (Observances): Personal disciplines and practices.
- Asana (Postures): Physical postures, a foundational aspect of yoga practice.
- Pranayama (Breath Control): Techniques to regulate and control the breath.

- Pratyahara (Withdrawal of the Senses): Turning inward and controlling the senses.
- Dharana (Concentration): Focusing the mind on a single point.
- Dhyana (Meditation): Sustained, focused concentration and mindfulness.
- Samadhi (Union/Absorption): A state of deep absorption and union with the Self.

21. What is Yoga? Provide a brief explanation of its origins. Yoga is a spiritual discipline rooted in ancient Indian philosophy. It is both a science and an art of healthy living, aimed at bringing harmony between the body, mind, and spirit. The word *Yoga* comes from the Sanskrit root "Yuj", which means "to join" or "to unite." According to Yogic scriptures, this union is the merging of individual consciousness with universal consciousness, resulting in a state of perfect balance and liberation known as moksha or kaivalya. Yoga encompasses various methods such as physical postures (asanas), breathing techniques (pranayama), meditation, and ethical disciplines to achieve self-realization and freedom from suffering.

Origins and Historical Development:

1. Pre-Vedic Period (2700 BCE):
   Evidence of Yoga-like postures was found in the Indus-Saraswati Valley Civilization, suggesting early forms of yogic practices.

2. Vedic Period (1500–900 BCE):
   The earliest mention of "Yoga" appears in the Rig Veda. The Vedic priests practiced rituals and breath control, laying the foundation for modern yogic techniques.

3. Pre-Classical Period:
   The Upanishads and Yoga Upanishads elaborated on the spiritual and meditative aspects of Yoga. Techniques such as pranayama, pratyahara, and dhyana were emphasized.

4. Classical Period (500 BCE–800 CE):
   This era saw the formal systematization of Yoga by Maharshi Patanjali, who authored the Yoga Sutras, defining the Eightfold Path (Ashtanga Yoga). Yoga also integrated into Buddhism and Jainism.

5. Post-Classical Period (800–1700 CE):
   Philosophers like Adi Shankaracharya and saints like Meera Bai emphasized Raja Yoga, Bhakti Yoga, and Hatha Yoga, focusing on mind purification and physical strength.

6. Modern Period (1700 CE–Present):
   Yogis such as Swami Vivekananda, B.K.S. Iyengar, and Pattabhi Jois helped spread Yoga globally. Today, Yoga is widely practiced for its mental, physical, and spiritual benefits.

22. Discuss about yoga prayer.
Prayers in yoga play a vital role in setting the tone for the practice. They create a sacred, mindful environment and help practitioners connect to the tradition and purpose of yoga. The opening prayer typically focuses on cultivating focus, respect for the practice, and unity among practitioners, while the closing prayer fosters gratitude, peace, and reflection on the practice.

Opening Prayer *(Sanskrit with Meaning)*

Sanskrit:

Om Saha Navavatu
Saha Nau Bhunaktu
Saha Viryam Karavavahai
Tejasvi Navadhitamastu Ma Vidvishavahai
Om Shanti Shanti Shantiḥ

Meaning:

- May we be protected together.
- May we be nourished together.
- May we work together with great energy.
- May our knowledge be illuminating and fruitful.
- May we live in harmony and peace.

Closing Prayer *(Sanskrit with Meaning)*

Sanskrit:

Om Asato Ma Sad Gamaya
Tamaso Ma Jyotir Gamaya
Mrityor Ma Amritam Gamaya
Om Shanti Shanti Shantiḥ

Meaning:

- Lead me from untruth to truth.
- Lead me from darkness to light.
- Lead me from death to immortality.
- Let there be peace, peace, peace.